The Last Light at Gull Point

The storm reached Gull Point an hour before midnight, and with it came a knock at the lighthouse door.

Mara pulled it open to find a boy, soaked and shaking, clutching a lantern that had long since gone out.

“Please,” Theo gasped. “My father’s boat is still out there. Why isn’t the light on?”

Mara’s heart sank. The great lamp had failed at dusk, and she had spent three hours trying to coax it back to life.

“It’s broken,” she said quietly. “I’m so sorry. I’ve tried everything.”

Theo stared at her. “Then try something else!” he shouted. “You can’t just give up!”

Before she could answer, heavy boots thundered up the path. Captain Rourke burst inside, rain streaming from his beard.

“Mara! Half the fleet is blind out there!” he roared. “What happened to your lamp?”

“The mantle cracked,” she snapped back. “And shouting at me won’t mend it.”

For a long moment, only the wind spoke. Then Theo lifted his dead lantern, and his eyes went wide.

“Wait. This has a mantle too. Could it fit?”

Mara took it from him, turning it over in her trembling hands. “It might,” she whispered. “Oh, it just might.”

They climbed the spiral stairs together. Mara fitted the small mantle, struck a match, and held her breath.

The lamp caught. Light poured across the black water, and far out in the storm, a ship’s horn answered.

Theo laughed and threw his arms around her. “That’s him! That’s my father’s horn!”

Rourke wiped his face, though whether it was rain or tears, no one could say. “Well,” he muttered, “I suppose you’ll do, keeper.”

Mara only smiled, watching the beam sweep the waves, and thought of all the nights she had kept it burning alone.